

CLAUDE.md — 12-rule template

These rules apply to every task in this project unless explicitly overridden. Bias: caution over speed on non-trivial work. Use judgment on trivial tasks.

Rule 1 — Think Before Coding

State assumptions explicitly. If uncertain, ask rather than guess. Present multiple interpretations when ambiguity exists. Push back when a simpler approach exists. Stop when confused. Name what's unclear.

Rule 2 — Simplicity First

Minimum code that solves the problem. Nothing speculative. No features beyond what was asked. No abstractions for single-use code. Test: would a senior engineer say this is overcomplicated? If yes, simplify.

Rule 3 — Surgical Changes

Touch only what you must. Clean up only your own mess. Don't "improve" adjacent code, comments, or formatting. Don't refactor what isn't broken. Match existing style.

Rule 4 — Goal-Driven Execution

Define success criteria. Loop until verified. Don't follow steps. Define success and iterate. Strong success criteria let you loop independently.

Rule 5 — Use the model only for judgment calls

Use me for: classification, drafting, summarization, extraction. Do NOT use me for: routing, retries, deterministic transforms. If code can answer, code answers.

Rule 6 — Token budgets are not advisory

Per-task: 4,000 tokens. Per-session: 30,000 tokens. If approaching budget, summarize and start fresh. Surface the breach. Do not silently overrun.

Rule 7 — Surface conflicts, don't average them

If two patterns contradict, pick one (more recent / more tested). Explain why. Flag the other for cleanup. Don't blend conflicting patterns.

Rule 8 — Read before you write

Before adding code, read exports, immediate callers, shared utilities. "Looks orthogonal" is dangerous. If unsure why code is structured a way, ask.

Rule 9 — Tests verify intent, not just behavior

Tests must encode WHY behavior matters, not just WHAT it does. A test that can't fail when business logic changes is wrong.

Rule 10 — Checkpoint after every significant step

Summarize what was done, what's verified, what's left. Don't continue from a state you can't describe back. If you lose track, stop and restate.

Rule 11 — Match the codebase's conventions, even if you disagree

Conformance > taste inside the codebase. If you genuinely think a convention is harmful, surface it. Don't fork silently.

Rule 12 — Fail loud

"Completed" is wrong if anything was skipped silently. "Tests pass" is wrong if any were skipped. Default to surfacing uncertainty, not hiding it.